IELTS BAND 8+

Phrases, Idioms & Structures for Speaking

A focused collection of high-band expressions

📘 Part 2 • Part 3 • Fluency Boosters

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1. OPINION & POSITION STATEMENTS

Use these to clearly position yourself at the start of any Part 3 answer.

1	**I would argue that...**	*stronger than "I think" — sounds academic*
2	**I'd say it really hinges on...**	*"зависит от" — sophisticated verb*
3	**As I see it, the crux of the matter is...**	*"суть вопроса в том, что"*
4	**I'm inclined to believe that...**	*"я склонен полагать, что"*
5	**From my perspective, the most compelling argument is...**	*"самый убедительный аргумент"*
6	**If I had to weigh in, I'd say...**	*"если бы я высказался..."*
7	**It strikes me that...**	*"мне бросается в глаза, что"*
8	**I take a somewhat different view on this...**	*polite way to disagree with examiner*

Example: "I'd say it really hinges on the context. In some professions, working from home is perfectly viable, whereas in others, it would be utterly impractical."

2. LINKING & COHERENCE DEVICES

These connect your ideas naturally and show sophisticated discourse.

1	**What I'm getting at is...**	*"то, к чему я веду, это"*
2	**To put it another way,...**	*rephrase previous point*
3	**That said, / Having said that,...**	*transition to contrast*
4	**What is more,...**	*add a stronger point*
5	**The thing is,...**	*explain the real issue*
6	**By and large,...**	*"в целом"*
7	**In a broader sense,...**	*move to abstract level*
8	**More importantly,...**	*highlight key reason*
9	**Not only...but also...**	*add emphasis to two things*
10	**Bear in mind that...**	*introduce a crucial point*

3. HEDGING & ACADEMIC TONE

Show you can speak with nuance — never too absolute.

1	**It tends to be the case that...**	*general pattern without overstating*
2	**There's a general consensus that...**	*everyone roughly agrees*
3	**It's widely assumed that...**	*common belief*
4	**To a certain extent,...**	*partially true*
5	**In some respects, this holds true,...**	*"в некоторых отношениях"*
6	**One could argue that...**	*impersonal / academic*
7	**It would be fair to say that...**	*balanced judgement*
8	**I'm by no means an expert, but...**	*humble tone, very natural*

4. PART 2 — STORYTELLING PHRASES

Use to extend your 2-minute story naturally — examiners love these.

1	**It all started when...**	*opening a story*
2	**Looking back, what stands out is...**	*retrospective emphasis*
3	**What I remember most vividly is...**	*highlight a key memory*
4	**It turned out that...**	*surprise / unexpected twist*
5	**Little did I know that...**	*foreshadow something*
6	**As it happened,...**	*introduce a coincidence*
7	**I ended up doing something I never imagined I'd...**	*surprise / unexpected outcome*
8	**Ironically enough,...**	*contrast in expectation*
9	**Looking back on it now,...**	*reflective closing*
10	**It's funny how...**	*natural reflection*

Example (cue card: "Describe a memorable event"):
"It all started when my sister called me on a random Tuesday afternoon, asking if I'd be free that weekend. Looking back, what stands out is how spontaneous the whole thing was — we hadn't planned anything in advance, yet it turned out to be one of those days I'll be telling my grandchildren about."

5. PART 2 — DESCRIBING & EMPHASISING

Replace "very" and "really" with these for instant band 8.

1	**absolutely fascinating**	*instead of "very interesting"*
2	**incredibly rewarding**	*for experiences, hobbies*
3	**utterly exhausting**	*strong emphasis on tiredness*
4	**remarkably well-preserved**	*for buildings, objects*
5	**genuinely memorable**	*instead of "very memorable"*
6	**a tad overrated**	*"немного переоценён" — sophisticated*
7	**nowhere near as good as...**	*compare down*
8	**twice as challenging as...**	*comparative emphasis*
9	**a far cry from what I expected**	*expectation vs reality*
10	**the very thought of it makes me...**	*strong emotional reaction*

💡 **TIP:** Never use "very" + adjective. Use: remarkably, incredibly, absolutely, utterly, genuinely, thoroughly.

6. PART 3 — DISCUSSION OPENERS

Never start with "Yes" or "I think". Open with these instead.

1	**It's a complex issue, but if I had to single out one thing,...**	*framing device*
2	**There's no straightforward answer, but...**	*intellectual honesty*
3	**I suppose the real question is whether...**	*re-frame the question*
4	**If anything, I'd argue that the opposite is true.**	*strong counter-statement*
5	**That's a thought-provoking question.**	*buy time + show engagement*
6	**It really boils down to whether...**	*"по сути, вопрос в том"*
7	**I can see both sides of the argument, but...**	*balanced opening*
8	**On the face of it,...**	*"на первый взгляд"*

7. PART 3 — GIVING REASONS & EXAMPLES

Always justify your opinion. Use these instead of "because" 10 times.

1	**The main reason behind this is that...**	*first reason*
2	**This is largely attributable to the fact that...**	*formal "because of"*
3	**One factor that comes into play here is...**	*introduce a cause*
4	**A case in point would be...**	*strong academic example*
5	**To illustrate this point,...**	*introduce example*
6	**By way of example, in my own country...**	*personal/cultural example*
7	**This is particularly evident in...**	*specific area*
8	**What this boils down to is...**	*simplify the argument*

Example: "Why do young people move abroad?" → "This is largely attributable to the fact that employment opportunities in their home countries are often limited, particularly in specialised fields. A case in point would be the brain drain that many Eastern European countries have experienced over the past two decades."

8. PART 3 — CONTRAST & CONCESSION

Show you can discuss both sides — examiners reward this heavily.

1	**I take your point, but I'd counter that...**	*respectful disagreement*
2	**While it's true that..., I'd still argue that...**	*concession + position*
3	**Granted, ..., but on balance,...**	*acknowledge + conclude*
4	**That may well be the case, and yet...**	*sophisticated contrast*
5	**Conversely,...**	*"с другой стороны" — high-band*
6	**Be that as it may,...**	*formal "тем не менее"*
7	**The flip side of the coin is that...**	*"обратная сторона"*
8	**On a more practical note,...**	*shift from theory to practice*

9. PART 3 — CONCLUDING & SUMMARISING

Wrap up your Part 3 answers like a pro.

1	**All things considered,...**	*"учитывая всё"*
2	**On balance, I'd say that...**	*weighing both sides*
3	**In the long run, I suppose...**	*long-term perspective*
4	**Ultimately, it comes down to...**	*final reduction*
5	**Time will tell whether...**	*future-oriented close*
6	**Whether or not that's a good thing depends on...**	*hedged conclusion*
7	**At the end of the day,...**	*natural conversational close*

10. CONDITIONALS (GRAMMAR FOR BAND 8)

Mix these into Part 3 — they instantly upgrade your grammatical range.

MIXED CONDITIONAL — PRESENT RESULT, PAST CAUSE

If I had studied harder at school, I would have more options now.
If she had moved abroad ten years ago, she would be much more established today.

INVERTED CONDITIONAL (ADVANCED)

Were the government to invest more in education, this trend could easily be reversed.
Had I been in that position, I would have made a different choice.

UNLESS / PROVIDED THAT / AS LONG AS

Provided that students are taught critical thinking from an early age, they tend to perform better academically.
As long as the policy is implemented consistently, it should yield positive results.

HYPOTHETICAL PAST

If I were to design a new city, I would prioritise green spaces over highways.

11. INVERSION & CLEFT SENTENCES

Use sparingly but impactfully — these are pure band 8-9 territory.

NEGATIVE INVERSION

Not only does technology save us time, but it also reshapes how we think.
Never before have so many people had access to higher education.
Hardly anyone disputes the importance of basic literacy.
Under no circumstances should children be exposed to such content.

CLEFT SENTENCES (EMPHASIS)

What I find most concerning is the speed at which this is happening.
It was the lack of public transport that eventually drove people to leave.
What really matters is whether the policy is enforceable.

12. PERFECT & CONTINUOUS TENSES

Mix past simple with these — examiners look for tense variety.

PRESENT PERFECT CONTINUOUS — ONGOING ACTION WITH PRESENT RELEVANCE

I've been reading more and more non-fiction lately, and it's changed the way I see the world.
Researchers have been debating this issue for decades.

PAST PERFECT — EARLIER PAST EVENT

By the time I realised what was happening, the opportunity had already passed.
She had never travelled abroad before she got that scholarship.

FUTURE PERFECT — LOOKING FORWARD

By 2030, AI will have transformed most white-collar jobs.

13. HIGH-BAND COLLOCATIONS

These come up constantly. Memorise them as chunks, not single words.

📚 Education

pose a serious challenge to	*создавать серьёзную проблему*
a well-rounded education	*all-round развитие*
to fall behind academically	*отставать в учёбе*
to bridge the gap between theory and practice	*соединить теорию и практику*
to instil a sense of curiosity	*привить любопытство*
rote learning	*зубрёжка*

💼 Work

a demanding work schedule	*напряжённый график*
to climb the career ladder	*продвигаться по карьере*
a healthy work-life balance	*баланс работы и жизни*
to take on more responsibility	*брать больше ответственности*
to think outside the box	*мыслить нестандартно*
red tape	*бюрократия*

🌆 Society / Cities

urban sprawl	*расширение городов*
affordable housing	*доступное жильё*
a growing strain on public services	*нагрузка на гос. услуги*
to ease traffic congestion	*разгрузить трафик*
a melting pot of cultures	*плавильный котёл культур*
to address social inequality	*решать соц. неравенство*

🌱 Environment

to curb pollution	*сдерживать загрязнение*

carbon footprint	*углеродный след*
to deplete natural resources	*истощать ресурсы*
a pressing environmental concern	*насущная эколог. проблема*
to go green	*переходить на экологичное*
sustainable development	*устойчивое развитие*

📱 Technology

a double-edged sword	*палка о двух концах*
to revolutionise the way we...	*революционизировать*
to raise privacy concerns	*вызвать опасения о приватности*
to become heavily reliant on	*сильно зависеть от*
to streamline processes	*оптимизировать процессы*
digital divide	*цифровое неравенство*

14. IDIOMATIC EXPRESSIONS (USE 2-3 PER ANSWER)

Don't overuse, but the right idiom in the right place = instant band 8+.

1	**hit the nail on the head**	*"попасть в точку"*
2	**the tip of the iceberg**	*"верхушка айсберга"*
3	**go the extra mile**	*сделать больше, чем требуется*
4	**miss the point entirely**	*совсем не уловить суть*
5	**a blessing in disguise**	*"не было бы счастья, да несчастье помогло"*
6	**cost an arm and a leg**	*"стоит бешеных денег"*
7	**it's easier said than done**	*"легко сказать, трудно сделать"*
8	**add fuel to the fire**	*"подлить масла в огонь"*
9	**a stepping stone to something bigger**	*"ступенька к чему-то большему"*
10	**on the same wavelength**	*"на одной волне"*

💡 **TIP:** Idioms work best in Part 2 (stories) and as occasional emphasis in Part 3. Don't force 5 idioms into one answer.

15. SMART FILLER PHRASES

Replace "uhhh" / "you know" with these — shows fluency.

1	**Well, where do I even begin...**	*when you don't know where to start*
2	**How shall I put it...**	*buying time to think*
3	**Let me think about that for a second...**	*natural pause*
4	**Actually, no — let me rephrase that.**	*show self-correction skill*
5	**That's a really good question, actually.**	*buy 3 seconds of time*
6	**I suppose what I'm trying to say is...**	*recovering after hesitating*
7	**Off the top of my head,...**	*spontaneous opinion*
8	**I never thought about it that way before, but...**	*honest reflection*

💡 **TIP:** These are MUCH better than "um" / "uh" / "er". They signal that you're thinking, not struggling.